PART IV · CHORDS · TIPS

When a chord sounds wrong

A chord that sounds wrong usually has one small slip. Name the slip, fix that one note, and the chord comes right.

TIP

What you notice, what to check

WHAT YOU NOTICE	CHECK	TURN TO
A chord sounds dark when it should be bright	**the kind**: keys between, 3 + 2 or 2 + 3	p. 89
Your hand jumps all over	**an inversion**: keep the shared note still	p. 95
A big chord sounds muddy	**leave notes out**: drop the 5th first	p. 104
A seventh chord sounds wrong	**the 7th**: G7 adds F, a 7th above G (9 keys between)	p. 98
A sus chord sounds unfinished	**the 4th**: the middle layer moved up a letter	p. 101
The bass note sounds odd	**the slash**: the letter after it is the lowest note	p. 107

Four ways to learn chords fast

1. **Build, then play**
   Say the cake (C E G) before your fingers go down.

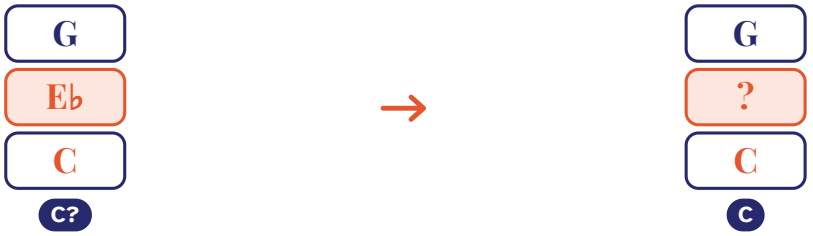
2. **Hands alone first**
   Left hand chords alone, then the tune alone, then together.

3. **One cake, three keys**
   Build the same kind of chord on C, G and F.

4. **Listen for the kind**
   Play major and minor side by side: bright, then dark.

EXAMPLE

Fix a dark chord



1. **It sounds dark**, but the music wants a bright C chord.
2. **Count the keys between:** C to E♭, then E♭ to G. Which kind is that?
3. **Move one note** so it becomes 3 + 2. Which layer, and to which key?

Move the middle layer from E♭ up to **E**: 3 + 2, bright C major again.

THINK OF IT Like a mechanic: one odd sound points to one part. Fix that part and the engine runs smoothly.